

The Tithe

What Scripture Actually Says

A Midrash Study from Abraham to Yahshua

Scripture quoted from the World English Bible, divine name rendered YHWH, Elohim, and Adonai. Torah is referred to throughout as the instructions of YHWH.

THE HEART OF IT

Few subjects stir up more guilt, more arguments, and more confusion than the tithe. Some were told that anything less than ten percent of their paycheck to the church is robbing Elohim. Others were told the tithe is dead and giving is optional.

This study sets both of those aside and asks one question: **what does the text actually say?** What was the tithe made of, who received it, what was it for, and how do we walk in the heart of it today without calling our own interpretation a commandment?

SECTION I

Before Torah: Abraham and Jacob

Most people were taught that tithing began with Abraham. So we start by reading exactly what Abraham did.

*Melchizedek king of Salem brought out bread and wine. He was priest of Elohim Most High. He blessed him, and said, "Blessed be Abram of Elohim Most High, possessor of heaven and earth. Blessed be Elohim Most High, who has delivered your enemies into your hand." **Abram gave him a tenth of all.***

GENESIS 14:18-20

Hebrews 7:4 tells us what that tenth came from: the spoils of the battle Abram had just won when he rescued Lot. It was not his wages, and nothing in the text says it was a yearly practice. It is one tenth, given one time, to one priest.

Then read the next few verses, which are rarely preached. Abram told the king of Sodom he would not take so much as a thread or a sandal strap, so that no one could say a man made Abram rich. He kept none of the remainder for himself. Only what his young men had eaten and the share of the allies who fought with him was set aside (**Genesis 14:22-24**).

Jacob's Vow

At Bethel, Jacob made a conditional vow. If Elohim would be with him, keep him on the journey, give him bread to eat and clothing to wear, and bring him back to his father's house in peace, then:

Of all that you will give me I will surely give a tenth to you.

GENESIS 28:22

That is a promise Jacob made, with conditions attached, not an instruction YHWH gave him.

WHAT WE LEARN

Before Torah we see one tenth from war spoils and one personal vow. Both show a heart that honors YHWH as the source of everything. **Neither one is a standing command, and neither one is a weekly percentage of wages.** For the command, we have to go to Torah.

SECTION II

What Torah Actually Says

All the tithe of the land, whether of the seed of the land, or of the fruit of the trees, is YHWH's. It is holy to YHWH.

LEVITICUS 27:30

Verse 32 adds every tenth animal of the herd and the flock, whatever passes under the rod. Look at what is on the list: **crops and animals**. The tithe was the increase of the land YHWH gave Israel.

Leviticus 27:30-33	The tithe of seed, fruit, herd, and flock is holy to YHWH. It may be redeemed with money by adding a fifth to its value.
Numbers 18:21-24	The tithe is given to the Levites as their inheritance in return for their service at the Tent of Meeting, because they have no land inheritance in Israel.
Numbers 18:26-28	The Levites give a tenth of the tithe they receive, the best of it, to the priests.
Deuteronomy 12:5-7, 17-18	The tithe is brought to the place YHWH chooses and eaten there before Him with rejoicing, with the Levite included.
Deuteronomy 14:22-27	The tithe of grain, new wine, and oil is eaten before YHWH at the place He chooses. If the distance is too great, it may be turned into money and spent there on food and drink for rejoicing.
Deuteronomy 14:28-29	Every third year the tithe is stored in the towns for the Levite, the foreigner, the fatherless, and the widow.
Deuteronomy 26:12-15	In the third year, the year of tithing, the giver declares before YHWH that he has given it as commanded.

The Tithe That Surprises People

You shall surely tithe all the increase of your seed, that which comes out of the field year by year. You shall eat before YHWH your Elohim, in the place which he shall choose to cause his name to dwell, the tithe of your grain, of your new wine, and of your oil, and the firstborn of your herd and of your flock; that you may learn to fear YHWH your Elohim always.

DEUTERONOMY 14:22-23

If the journey was too long to carry it, Israel could sell the tithe, carry the money, and then spend it at the feast on whatever they desired: cattle, sheep, wine, or strong drink. Then they were to eat before YHWH and rejoice with their household, and not forsake the Levite (**Deuteronomy 14:24-27**). **Part of the tithe paid for celebrating before YHWH.** The stated purpose was that they would learn to fear Him always.

The Third Year Tithe

At the end of every three years you shall bring all the tithe of your increase in the same year, and shall store it within your gates. The Levite, because he has no portion nor inheritance with you, as well as the foreigner living among you, the fatherless, and the widow who are within your gates shall come, and shall eat and be satisfied; that YHWH your Elohim may bless you in all the work of your hand which you do.

DEUTERONOMY 14:28-29

Where Money Shows Up

In the tithe instructions, money appears in only two places: to **carry** the tithe to the feast when the distance is too far (**Deuteronomy 14:24-25**), and to **redeem** it by paying its value plus a fifth (**Leviticus 27:31**). In both cases the tithe itself is still produce and animals.

Tithe and Firstfruits Are Not the Same

The firstfruits were a separate offering: the first of the harvest, brought in a basket to the priest with a spoken confession of what YHWH had done (**Exodus 23:19; Deuteronomy 26:1-11**). The tithe was a tenth of the increase. Scripture keeps them distinct, and so should we.

WHERE SCRIPTURE STOPS

Jewish tradition counts these as separate tithes: one for the Levites, a second eaten at the feasts, and a third year tithe for the poor. Others read them as one tithe used in different ways. **The text does not settle the count for us,** so we will not build a rule on it.

What the text does settle is the purpose. The tithe fed those who served YHWH, paid for rejoicing before Him, and fed the foreigner, the fatherless, and the widow.

SECTION III

Malachi 3 in Context

*Will a man rob Elohim? Yet you rob me! But you say, "How have we robbed you?" In tithes and offerings. You are cursed with the curse; for you rob me, even this whole nation. Bring the whole tithe into the storehouse, **that there may be food in my house**, and test me now in this, says YHWH of Armies, if I will not open you the windows of heaven, and pour you out a blessing, that there will not be room enough for.*

MALACHI 3:8-10

Malachi prophesied after Judah returned from exile and the temple was rebuilt, around the same period as Nehemiah. Nehemiah lets us see what the storehouse was and what had gone wrong.

- The people covenanted to bring the tithes of their ground to the Levites, and the Levites were to bring a tenth of those tithes up to the storerooms of the house of Elohim. **Nehemiah 10:37-39**
- Nehemiah found the Levites had not been given their portions, so the Levites and singers had fled back to their own fields to survive. **Nehemiah 13:10**
- He set it right, and all Judah brought the tithe of the grain, new wine, and oil into the treasuries. **Nehemiah 13:11-12**

The storehouse was rooms in the temple stocked with **food** for the Levites and priests who served there. Malachi says so himself: that there may be food in my house.

Notice also who YHWH says He will judge just two verses earlier: those who oppress the hired worker in his wages, the widow, and the fatherless, and those who turn away the foreigner (**Malachi 3:5**). Those are the very people the tithe was meant to feed.

TWO COMMON MISREADINGS

The storehouse is the church building. The text never says this. The storehouse in Malachi and Nehemiah is temple storerooms holding produce for the Levites.

Malachi only rebuked the priests. This one is popular on the other side of the debate, and it does not hold either. Malachi 3:9 says the whole nation was robbing Him. The people held back the tithe, the Levites went hungry, and the service of YHWH's house broke down.

SECTION IV

Yahshua and the Tithe

Yahshua rebuked the scribes and Pharisees for tithing mint, dill, and cumin while leaving undone the weightier matters: justice, mercy, and faith. Then He said they ought to have done those weightier things **without leaving the tithe undone** (**Matthew 23:23; Luke 11:42**).

He did not throw the tithe out. He put it in its place, underneath justice, mercy, and faith. Any teaching that says Yahshua abolished the tithe has to explain this verse, and it cannot.

The Tither Who Went Home Unjustified

I fast twice a week. I give tithes of all that I get.

LUKE 18:12

Those are the words of the Pharisee in Yahshua's parable, standing beside a tax collector who could only beat his chest and ask for mercy. Yahshua said the tax collector went home justified rather than the tither (**Luke 18:9-14**). **A perfect tithe with a proud heart is not righteousness.** Pride can hide inside giving just as easily as it hides inside withholding.

SECTION V

Giving in the Assembly

The apostolic writings say a great deal about giving. Here is what they actually teach.

Galatians 6:6	Let him who is taught in the word share all good things with him who teaches.
1 Corinthians 9:13-14	Paul ties it back to the altar: those who serve at the altar share in it, and those who proclaim the good news should live from it.
1 Timothy 5:17-18	Elders who labor in the word are worthy of double honor. Paul quotes Deuteronomy 25:4, do not muzzle the ox while it treads the grain.
Philippians 4:15-18	The Philippians supported Paul's work more than once, and he calls their gift a sweet smelling sacrifice, well pleasing to Elohim.
1 Corinthians 16:1-3	A collection set aside for the saints in Jerusalem during hardship. It was relief for believers in need, not a tithe.
Acts 4:34-35	No one among them lacked, because distribution was made to each according to need.
Acts 20:35	Paul reminds the elders of Yahshua's words, that it is more blessed to give than to receive.
James 1:27	Pure religion is to visit the fatherless and widows in their affliction, and to keep oneself unstained by the world.

Let each man give according as he has determined in his heart, not grudgingly or under compulsion, for Elohim loves a cheerful giver.

2 CORINTHIANS 9:7

WHERE SCRIPTURE STOPS

No verse in the apostolic writings sets a percentage for believers, and none names a local congregation as the storehouse. **If we preach a rule the text does not give, we are calling an interpretation a commandment.**

What the text does give is plain: support those who teach you, care for the fatherless and the widow, meet the needs of the saints, and give from a willing heart, not under pressure.

SECTION VI

How Our Family Walks It Out

Today there is no temple standing and no Levites serving at an altar to receive the tithe. So we asked what the heart of the tithe is that we can still walk in, and we let Torah answer. In our home we set aside our first ten percent before anything else, and it goes to four places:

Keeping the feasts	Part of the tithe was eaten before YHWH with rejoicing. Deuteronomy 14:23-26
Homeless care bags	The third year tithe fed the foreigner, the fatherless, and the widow. Deuteronomy 14:28-29; Matthew 25:35-40
Blessing someone in need	He who has pity on the poor lends to YHWH; he will reward him. Proverbs 19:17; 1 John 3:17
Supporting ministries	Those who teach the word are to share in the good things of those they teach. Galatians 6:6; 1 Corinthians 9:14

We share this as **how we apply the pattern**, not as a rule for anyone else. Torah names produce and animals, and we have chosen to follow its purposes with what YHWH gives us now. Where Scripture stops speaking, we stop too.

SECTION VII

What This Does Not Mean

- **It does not mean stop giving.** Yahshua told the Pharisees not to leave the tithe undone, and the apostles taught generous, cheerful giving everywhere they went.
- **It is not an attack on pastors or teachers.** Scripture says those who labor in the word are worthy of support. The question is honesty about what the text says, not whether to support them.
- **It does not throw out YHWH's instructions.** We are asking what the tithe actually was so we can honor its purpose, not looking for a way out of it.
- **It does not give anyone permission to judge someone else's giving.** Each one gives as he has determined in his heart. That is between them and YHWH.
- **Nobody should be pressured, threatened with a curse, or shamed into giving.** Compulsion is the one thing Paul says giving must never be.

SECTION VIII

Walking It Out This Week

Practical, testable, and small enough to actually do.

- 1 **Read Deuteronomy 14:22-29 as a family.** Talk about what the tithe was made of, who it fed, and why YHWH wanted His people rejoicing before Him.

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- 2 Check your heart before your budget.** Ask YHWH whether you give grudgingly, out of fear, or to be seen. Repent of any pride hiding in your giving or your withholding.
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- 3 Set aside first, not last.** Decide on what you will set apart and put it aside before anything else is spent, so giving is not made from leftovers.
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- 4 Plan for the next feast.** Put something aside now so your household can rejoice before YHWH when the appointed time comes.
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- 5 Feed someone this week.** The fatherless, the widow, the stranger, the man on the corner. Do it quietly.
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- 6 Support someone who teaches you.** Send a gift, meet a need, or write an honest word of thanks to someone who has fed you the word.
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- 7 Forgive anyone who used giving against you.** If you were shamed, pressured, or cursed over money, release it to YHWH out loud. Bitterness over it is ground the enemy should not have.
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SECTION IX

Cross Reference Index

Before Torah: Genesis 14:17-24; Genesis 28:20-22; Hebrews 7:1-10

The tithe in Torah: Leviticus 27:30-33; Numbers 18:21-32; Deuteronomy 12:5-7, 17-19; Deuteronomy 14:22-29; Deuteronomy 26:12-15

Firstfruits: Exodus 23:19; Deuteronomy 26:1-11

Return and the storehouse: 2 Chronicles 31:4-12; Nehemiah 10:35-39; Nehemiah 12:44; Nehemiah 13:10-13; Malachi 3:5-12

Yahshua on the tithe: Matthew 23:23; Luke 11:42; Luke 18:9-14

Supporting those who teach: Deuteronomy 25:4; 1 Corinthians 9:7-14; Galatians 6:6; Philippians 4:15-18; 1 Timothy 5:17-18

Care for the poor: Deuteronomy 15:7-11; Proverbs 19:17; Matthew 25:35-40; Acts 4:32-35; James 1:27; 1 John 3:17-18

The heart of giving: Proverbs 3:9-10; Matthew 6:1-4; Mark 12:41-44; Acts 20:35; 2 Corinthians 8:1-15; 2 Corinthians 9:6-8

NOTES

Personal Notes and Convictions

Kingdom Life Ministry
Restoring YHWH's design for marriage, family, forgiveness, and deliverance.

Walk in truth, walk in light. Shalom.